

It was one of the rarest opportunities to spend some time with the man I've always looked up to since I migrated to GNU/Linux systems. The father of the free software movement, Richard M. Stallman was in Delhi for three days, and during the time I spent with RMS, we discussed various topics that helped me get to the bottom of why 'Free Software' matters so much. This frank discussion with RMS also covers topics like the entire confusion created around patents and copyright, what a sensible government should do, why free software matters for an enterprise as well as a developer and what will happen to the free software movement after RMS... though we wish him to live another 100 years. So read on...

Chilly Pepper: This is the first interview in which RMS has responded to a recent blog post by Linus Torvalds, where the creator of the Linux kernel has criticised the father of the free software movement.

Q I would like to start off with what free software is all about, according to you?

Free software means software that respects the user's freedom and the user community. Proprietary software traps the user's freedom and divides the user, leaving him helpless. They are divided because they are forbidden to share the source code. Helpless because they don't get the source code; hence they can't change the program and they can't even verify what it is doing to them. Free software respects that and there are four essential freedoms that a user must have.

Zero is the freedom to run the program as you wish. Freedom One is the freedom to study the source code of the program and then change it to make the program do what you wish. Freedom Two is to help your neighbour, which means to make exact copies of the program and distribute it to others when you wish. And Freedom Three is the freedom to contribute to your community, which means distribute modified versions when you wish.

Now, this has nothing to do with the details of what the program does and how. It's about what you are allowed to do with the program. So, if one of these freedoms is missing, or partly missing, then the social system of a distribution is unethical, and that makes it proprietary software. So, that software should not exist, because every time someone uses it, it becomes a social problem.

Q To whom does free software matter?

It matters to everybody who uses software. So, if you have a computer these freedoms are important to you and you deserve free software.

Q Is there any particular reason why free software makes more sense in a country like India?

I don't think so. I think freedom is essential for everyone. The only country where free software doesn't matter is the country where nobody uses computers.

Q Why is it important for governments?

All users of software deserve the four freedoms and that includes government agencies. However, in their case it's not just what they deserve, it's their duty, it's their responsibility. Because the government has a responsibility to maintain its sovereignty, i.e., control over what they do. So a government agency that does computing has a duty to maintain control over its computing, which means it must use free software.

Q What are the kinds of relations that exist between the governments and the free software community around the globe?

It depends on which government—they are not all doing the same things. Some governments have explicitly adopted a policy of moving government agencies to free software. These include Venezuela, Ecuador, apart from others who are migrating to free software though they don't have a formal policy.

Then there are some governments like the US government that has no pride, no ethics, and basically just sells out to multinational corporations. And then there are some governments that are very concerned about letting those corporations have power and try to resist it. And while doing so they also defend their citizens from those corporations.

Q And what about education? Now there are two aspects to that: using free software in the IT infrastructure of schools, as well as getting it into the curriculum.

Well, regarding the administration of the school, they deserve to use free software just like everyone else. What is especially important is what software they teach students. Because schools have influence over society and they have a social mission—which is to teach the next generation to be good citizens of a strong, capable, independent, cooperating and free society. In the field of computing, this means that their responsibility is to teach students to be users of free software and to appreciate and applaud the freedoms of free software.

If a school is teaching proprietary programs, that means it is selling dependency to the next generation, directing them under the power of a particular company. This is something schools must never do. In addition, some students are people who will be fascinated with computers and will learn to be great programmers. When they get interested in programming, which is usually between the age group of 10 and 13, they want to learn how the software